

BRICKS BUILDER · WOOCOMMERCE

Responsive Design Process for Ecommerce Sites

A stage-by-stage workflow for desktop, tablet and mobile
— with practical working tips

The Short Answer First

You do NOT build separate mobile and tablet pages. In Bricks Builder (like all modern builders) you build ONE page, and you adjust how it behaves at each breakpoint. There is only one set of content and one URL — the layout adapts.

Bricks works desktop-first by default: any style you set at the base (desktop) breakpoint automatically cascades DOWN to tablet and mobile. You then only override the things that need to change at smaller sizes (column counts, font sizes, spacing, menu type).

So the practical workflow is:

- Plan mobile from day one (content priority, navigation, thumb reach) — even before you open Bricks.
- Set up global styles and fluid units so 80% of the design adapts on its own.
- Build each page/template at the desktop breakpoint.
- Immediately walk that same page down through tablet → mobile landscape → mobile portrait, overriding only what breaks.
- Test on real devices, especially the checkout flow.

KEY MINDSET

“Desktop-first building, mobile-first thinking.” You physically build in the desktop view, but every decision (structure, units, element choice) is made knowing it must collapse gracefully to a 375px-wide phone screen — where 60–75% of your ecommerce traffic will be.

How Bricks Handles Breakpoints

Bricks ships with four default breakpoints, editable under Bricks → Settings → Custom Breakpoints:

- Desktop (base) — your default canvas; styles here apply everywhere unless overridden.
- Tablet portrait — max-width 991px.
- Mobile landscape — max-width 767px.
- Mobile portrait — max-width 478px.

Important behaviours to understand before you start:

- Cascade direction: desktop styles flow down to smaller breakpoints. A tablet override also flows down to mobile unless mobile has its own override.
- Breakpoint-specific styling: with a smaller breakpoint selected in the builder toolbar, any style you change applies to that breakpoint and below — content and structure stay shared.
- You can add custom breakpoints (e.g. a large-desktop 1440px+ one) and even switch Bricks to mobile-first mode, but for most ecommerce builds the default desktop-first cascade is simpler and is the widely used practice.
- Content (text, images, element order in the DOM) is the same across breakpoints — only styling differs. To reorder visually on mobile, use CSS order or flex-direction overrides, not duplicated sections.

TIP

Resist the temptation to duplicate a section, style one “for desktop” and one “for mobile”, then hide each with `display:none`. Both versions still load (hurting performance and Core Web Vitals) and duplicate content/DOM weight. Use it only as a last resort for radically different layouts — e.g. a desktop mega-menu vs. a mobile off-canvas menu.

STAGE 1 Plan & Wireframe (Mobile Content First)

Before touching Bricks, decide what matters on a small screen. Ecommerce pages die on mobile when they are desktop layouts squeezed thin.

- List every template you need: home, shop/category, single product, cart, checkout, account, search results, blog, contact, policy pages.
- For each, rank content by priority. On mobile the top of a product page should be: image → title → price → variations → add-to-cart. Reviews, long descriptions and cross-sells come after.
- Sketch mobile wireframes first (even on paper), then expand them to desktop. It is far easier to enrich a mobile layout for desktop than to compress a desktop layout for mobile.
- Decide navigation early: sticky header? off-canvas menu? bottom bar with cart/search icons? Persistent mini-cart?
- Plan thumb-reach: primary actions (Add to Cart, Checkout) should be full-width buttons in the lower two-thirds of the viewport where possible.

TIP

Check your analytics (or industry defaults) for the real device split. If 70% of buyers are on phones, mobile IS the primary design — desktop is the enhancement.

STAGE 2 Global Setup Before Building Anything

This stage saves you the most time. Good global settings mean most pages need only minor breakpoint tweaks later.

2.1 Theme Styles & Variables

- Set up Bricks Theme Styles (or a framework like Core Framework / Automatic.css) for colours, spacing scale and typography BEFORE building pages.
- Use CSS variables for spacing (`--space-s/m/l/xl`) so you can retune the whole site's density per breakpoint in one place.

2.2 Fluid Typography & Spacing

- Use `clamp()` for headings so they scale smoothly without breakpoint overrides, e.g. `font-size: clamp(1.75rem, 4vw + 1rem, 3rem)`.
- Use `rem/em` for text and padding, `%` or `fr` for widths. Avoid fixed `px` widths and fixed heights — they are the #1 cause of mobile breakage.
- Set section padding with variables or `clamp()` so vertical rhythm compresses automatically on small screens.

2.3 Layout Primitives

- Product grids: use CSS Grid with `grid-template-columns: repeat(auto-fill, minmax(240px, 1fr))`. The grid reflows 4 → 3 → 2 columns by itself with zero breakpoint overrides.
- Everything else: prefer flexbox with gap (not margins between siblings) so wrapping stays clean.
- Set a global container max-width (e.g. 1200–1360px) with side padding via a variable (e.g. `clamp(1rem, 4vw, 2.5rem)`).

2.4 Breakpoints & Builder Settings

- Review Bricks → Settings → Custom Breakpoints. The defaults (991 / 767 / 478) are fine for most stores; add a 1440px+ breakpoint only if you design very wide layouts.
- Build reusable components as Bricks Global Elements / Templates (header, footer, product card, CTA sections) — fix responsiveness once, reuse everywhere.

TIP

The goal of Stage 2: when you later shrink the viewport, the page should already be ~80% correct before you touch a single breakpoint override.

STAGE 3 Build the Desktop Layout (Responsively)

Now build each template at the base/desktop breakpoint — but with responsive discipline:

- Structure with semantic nesting: Section → Container → Block/Div → elements. Shallow, tidy structure is much easier to adapt per breakpoint.
- Use % / fr / auto widths on columns, never fixed pixel widths.
- Never set fixed heights on sections or cards; let content define height (use min-height if you must).
- Use gap for spacing between columns and cards instead of left/right margins.
- Add images with correct aspect ratios (aspect-ratio CSS or Bricks setting) so cards don't jump around while loading.
- Build templates in this order: header/footer → product card component → shop archive → single product → home → cart/checkout → secondary pages.

TIP

Drag the builder canvas edge narrower every 15–20 minutes while building desktop. Catching a rigid structure early costs 2 minutes; discovering it after building 10 sections costs an afternoon.

STAGE 4 Walk It Down: Tablet (991px)

With a page finished on desktop, click the tablet breakpoint in the Bricks toolbar and fix only what breaks. Typical tablet overrides for ecommerce:

- Product grid: 4 columns → 3 (or let auto-fill minmax handle it).
- Two-column hero/feature rows: reduce gap, or stack if text gets cramped (flex-direction: column).
- Header: often switch to the mobile menu already at tablet — full nav bars rarely fit at 768–991px.
- Single product: keep gallery + summary side-by-side if there is room; reduce padding.
- Reduce oversized section padding (e.g. 120px → 80px) if not already fluid.

Work top-to-bottom through the page once, then move on. Do not perfect it pixel-by-pixel yet — you will do a QA pass in Stage 7.

STAGE 5 Walk It Down: Mobile (767px & 478px)

Select mobile landscape, fix what breaks, then mobile portrait — the one that matters most. Typical mobile overrides:

- Stack all multi-column rows (flex-direction: column) and check the resulting ORDER makes sense; use CSS order to put image above text where needed.
- Product grid: 2 columns on portrait (1 column only for large editorial cards).
- Typography: check clamp() results; body text minimum 16px to avoid iOS zoom-on-focus in forms.
- Buttons: full-width, min-height ~44–48px (Apple/Google touch-target guidance); at least 8px between adjacent tap targets.
- Header: compact sticky header with logo, hamburger, search and cart icons. Consider a sticky “Add to Cart” bar on product pages.
- Hide truly non-essential decorative elements at this breakpoint (sparingly) — remember hidden elements still load.
- Kill horizontal scroll: it is almost always caused by fixed widths, unwrapped flex rows, oversized images, or negative margins. Fix the cause, don’t just add overflow-x:hidden.
- Tables (size charts, specs): make them horizontally scrollable in a wrapper or restructure as stacked cards.

TIP

Preview at 375px width (iPhone standard) and 360px (common Android), not just Bricks’ 478px canvas. If it works at 360px it works almost everywhere.

STAGE 6 Ecommerce-Specific Mobile Patterns

Shop / Category pages

- Filters: off-canvas drawer or collapsible accordion triggered by a “Filter” button — never a permanent sidebar on mobile.
- Show 2-column product cards with price and title visible without tapping; keep card tap area generous.

Single product page

- Swipeable image gallery with pinch-zoom; first image visible without scrolling.
- Price + variations + Add to Cart within the first 1.5 screen heights; sticky add-to-cart bar for long pages.
- Collapse long description, shipping info and reviews into accordions.

Cart & Checkout

- One column, minimal distractions; remove header nav clutter on checkout if possible.
- Large quantity steppers (tiny +/- buttons are a conversion killer).
- Correct input types (email, tel, numeric) and autocomplete attributes so mobile keyboards behave.
- Express payment buttons (Apple Pay / Google Pay) near the top — they dramatically reduce mobile friction.
- Test the ENTIRE purchase flow on a real phone before launch. This is non-negotiable.

Performance (part of mobile design, not an afterthought)

- Serve responsive image sizes (WordPress srcset does this — don’t override with full-size images).
- Lazy-load below-the-fold images; eager-load the hero/product image (LCP).
- Keep sliders/animations minimal on mobile; aim for LCP < 2.5s on 4G.

STAGE 7 Test, QA & Iterate

- Chrome DevTools device toolbar: test 360, 375, 390, 414, 768, 820, 1024, 1280, 1440px — and the awkward in-between widths, not just presets.
- Real devices: at least one iPhone (Safari!) and one Android. Safari has its own quirks (viewport height, form styling, sticky behaviour).
- Full-flow test: browse → filter → product → variations → cart → checkout → order confirmation, on mobile.
- Rotate devices: check landscape orientation doesn't break the header or hero.
- Run Lighthouse (mobile) on home, category, product and checkout; fix CLS from images without dimensions and LCP from heavy heroes.
- Accessibility pass: colour contrast, focus states, logical heading order, labels on form fields.
- After launch: watch analytics for mobile drop-off points (usually filters or checkout) and iterate.

One-Page Cheat Sheet

The process at a glance:

- 1. PLAN — wireframe mobile-first; rank content priority per template.
- 2. GLOBALS — theme styles, CSS variables, clamp() typography, fluid spacing, auto-fill product grids, breakpoints reviewed.
- 3. BUILD DESKTOP — one page at a time, %/rem/fr units, no fixed widths/heights, gap not margins.
- 4. TABLET PASS — select 991px, fix columns, nav, padding.
- 5. MOBILE PASS — 767px then 478px: stack, reorder, full-width 44px+ buttons, kill horizontal scroll.
- 6. ECOM PATTERNS — drawer filters, sticky add-to-cart, accordion product info, streamlined 1-column checkout, express pay.
- 7. TEST — real devices, full purchase flow, Lighthouse mobile, iterate.

Golden rules:

- One page, three-plus views — never separate mobile pages.
- Styles cascade down: set once on desktop, override only what breaks.
- Fluid units first, breakpoint overrides second, hide/duplicate last (and rarely).
- The mobile checkout is the most valuable screen on the whole site — give it the most testing time.